Kim Jong-un, while radical factions seized the moment to court disaffected Sikhs. A day after the SAD vote, Faridkot MP Sarabjeet Singh Khalsa—under the banner of Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De)—held a rally during Baisakhi celebrations at Takht Damdama Sahib, announcing the outfit's plans to contest the 2027 state polls led by Khadoor Sahib MP and jailed Khalistani separatist Amritpal Singh.

The SAD's decline has been stark. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, its candidates forfeited deposit in 11 of Punjab's 13 seats, scraping just 13.24 per cent of the vote—a historic low. Earlier, in the 2022 state election, the party won only three of 117 seats with 18 per cent of the vote. Internal dissent has since grown. After the Lok Sabha rout, Banga MLA Sukhwinder Kumar Sukhi defected to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), while Dakha MLA Manpreet Singh Ayali refused to work under Sukhbir. Meanwhile, a group of top leaders, including Gurpartap Singh Wadala, Prem Singh Chandumajra and Bibi Jagir Kaur, briefly formed a reformist faction before disbanding in December, ostensibly to reunify the party.

Now, Sukhbir's rivals within the Akali Dal have challenged the legitimacy of the party's membership drive, delegate selection and his own "re-elevation", claiming he heads only a faction—not the Shiromani (i.e. supreme) Akali Dal. They insist on a fresh drive, as directed by the Akal Takht, before a new leader is elected. But Sukhbir's supporters argue he was targeted to weaken the party and, having taken the blame and undergone *tankha* (religious censure), he is poised to regain the wider support of the Sikh community.

Founded in 1920 during the Gurdwara Reform Movement, the SAD is India's second-oldest party after the Congress. Sukhbir has led it since 2008, succeeding his father—then CM Parkash Singh Badal. The latter, who helmed the party for 13 years, had consolidated various Akali factions in 1995 at the pivotal Moga convention in the post-militancy era. But under Sukhbir's leadership, critics say, it strayed from its roots as a voice for rural Sikhs and farmers, instead becoming a vehicle for wealthy landlords.

More damaging have been controversies that alienated Sikh voters during the 10-year SAD rule (2007-17): the 2012 appointment of Sumedh Singh Saini—a police officer accused of human rights abuses during the Sikh militancy—as state police chief; drug trafficking allegations against Akali leaders (substance abuse is barred in Sikhism); the 2015 desecration of the Guru Granth Sahib; and a baffling religious pardon to the controversial preacher Gurmeet Ram Rahim in a blasphemy case. In December last year, Sukhbir publicly admitted to several such failings before the Akal Takht, while accepting his *tankha* for misconduct. But in March this year, his close aides were accused of orchestrating the removal of three Sikh high priests, including the Akal Takht jathedar, who were pivotal in imposing that censure.

Now, with his re-election, the scepticism has only deepened. For Sukhbir, the challenge is twofold: to reunite a fractured party and restore its credibility. Neither will be easy. ■

SUKHBIR'S RE-ELECTION AND THE EVENTS LEADING UP TO IT HAVE FURTHER DIMMED HOPES OF A REVIVAL FOR THE CENTURY-OLD PARTY, WHICH HAS SEEN ITS INFLUENCE ERODE DRAMATICALLY



By Kaleem Geelani

In 2021, 48-year-old Gulzar Ahmad Bhat poured his life savings into transforming his traditional apple orchard in Pulwama's Chandgam village into a modern high-density one. The investment of Rs 13.5 lakh—Rs 10 lakh on 1,235 New Zealand-origin Schino Gala saplings and the rest on land development and drip irrigation—seemed worthwhile. His annual income, which had hovered around Rs 5–6 lakh for three decades, shot up to Rs 16 lakh within two years as yields touched 1,200 boxes.

But in July 2024, a single pesticide spray wiped it all out. "It was an apocalypse. Our only source of income vanished overnight," Bhat tells INDIA TODAY. The pesticide, sold by a registered dealer, turned his 8-kanal orchard into a wasteland. He's now fighting a legal battle against a Gujarat-based chemical firm, the dealer and the district horticulture office, seeking compensation. The Jammu and